

snapsight

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Actionable Insights from IMEX Frankfurt

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IMPACT 2.0
ACTIVATING THE FUTURE

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1. Executive Summary

IMEX Frankfurt 2025 served as a pivotal gathering for the global business events industry, marked by an urgent and pervasive call to move from **"Intention to Action."** The conference illuminated an industry at a significant inflection point, grappling with rapid technological advancements, pressing socio-economic shifts, and a deepening commitment to sustainability and purpose. This report synthesizes the dominant themes, evolving narratives, and strategic imperatives that emerged, offering a comprehensive blueprint for navigating the future.

Key insights reveal an industry profoundly impacted by the **AI revolution**. Discussions moved beyond nascent adoption to strategic integration for enhanced efficiency, deep personalization, novel engagement models, and sophisticated data analytics. However, this technological surge is coupled with critical considerations around ethics, data privacy (GDPR), and the irreplaceable value of human creativity, encapsulated in concepts like Colja Dams' "AI Hamburger." **Sustainability and ESG principles** have transitioned from peripheral concerns to core business drivers. The dialogue emphasized holistic integration, moving towards **regenerative event models** that aim for a net positive impact. This includes tangible actions in environmental stewardship (decarbonization, circular economy, sustainable catering), social responsibility (community engagement, DEIB), and authentic, transparent communication to combat greenwashing.

The **human element** remains paramount. Experience design is increasingly focused on engineering emotions, fostering genuine connections to combat loneliness, and creating memorable, transformative moments. Storytelling, play (LEGO® SERIOUS PLAY®), and human-centric marketing are key to engaging diverse audiences with diminishing attention spans. Concurrently, the **role of the event professional is evolving** from logistician to strategic architect, demanding new skills in data analysis, creative design, technological fluency, and empathetic leadership. Talent attraction, retention, and development – including fostering intergenerational collaboration and recognizing unconventional leadership paths – are critical for future-proofing the industry. **Diversity, Equity, Inclusion, and Belonging (DEIB)** were central, with a clear push from awareness to concrete action. This includes addressing gender imbalances, ensuring LGBTQ+ and non-binary inclusion, designing for neurodiversity and accessibility (driven partly by regulations like the European Accessibility Act), and reframing caregiving as a source of leadership potential.

Business models are under intense scrutiny, with a focus on demonstrating holistic ROI (beyond traditional metrics to include ROE and ROO), navigating rising costs through innovative budgeting and negotiation, and rethinking sponsorship from mere visibility to performance-based engagement. The evolution of subventions to support sustainability and

legacy, alongside the influence of the "purpose economy," signals a shift towards greater strategic alignment and impact.

Destinations and convention bureaus are also transforming, becoming active co-creators of impactful events with lasting legacies, rather than just service providers. This involves strategic alignment with national agendas, innovative marketing, and robust cross-destination collaboration.

While opportunities for innovation and positive change abound, significant **challenges** persist. These include bridging the AI adoption gap, the perceived cost of sustainability, maintaining authentic human connection in a digital age, addressing talent shortages and burnout, systemically implementing DEIB, and navigating economic volatility and geopolitical instability.

Ultimately, IMEX Frankfurt 2025 underscored that the future of the business events industry lies in its ability to strategically integrate technology, embed sustainability and purpose into its core, design deeply human and inclusive experiences, nurture adaptable talent, and collaboratively redefine value and success in an ever-evolving global landscape. The path forward demands courage, creativity, and a collective commitment to translating ambitious intentions into tangible, measurable, and impactful actions.

2. Key Themes and Trends

The sessions at IMEX Frankfurt 2025 converged around several pivotal themes, reflecting the industry's current priorities and future trajectory. This analysis decodes the dominant narratives, from the revolutionary impact of technology to the profound re-evaluation of human-centric experiences and sustainable practices.

2.1 Transformative Technologies and the AI Revolution

The integration of technology, particularly Artificial Intelligence (AI), was a dominant theme, signaling a paradigm shift in how events are conceived, planned, executed, and experienced. Discussions emphasized that AI is no longer a futuristic concept but a present-day toolset revolutionizing the industry.

2.1.1 AI Literacy, Ethics, and Strategic Implementation

A foundational message was the necessity of **AI literacy and prompt engineering** for all event professionals. Jeanne Sheehy of Bostrom and Sarah Timm of Parthenon Management Group, in their "Top 10 Tech Skills" session, demonstrated leveraging ChatGPT for presentation crafting and Google Notebook for event podcast generation, advocating for resources like the "There's an AI for That" newsletter. Henry Coutinho-Mason, in "Thriving in the AI era," echoed this by showcasing AI's potential in creating event soundtracks and enhancing Q&A sessions, while cautioning against a mere "fetishization of AI technology."

"It's part of our jobs to really get them out of that, to get them to experiment, to take them step by step in learning these new tools."

— Jeanne Sheehy, **Top 10 tech skills defining the next era of meetings**

The ethical implications and the need for clear AI policies were also paramount. Sarah Timm stressed the importance of organizations developing clear AI usage policies and ensuring GDPR compliance. This concern was echoed in the "Enhancing event experiences: AI and digital innovations" session, which highlighted the importance of comprehensive AI policies to address data privacy and cybersecurity.

2.1.2 AI in Event Design, Personalization, and Content Creation

AI's role in **enhancing event experiences** was a recurring topic. Colja Dams of Fogdams, in "Redefining events: Shaping tomorrow's experiences," presented a plethora of AI tools like OpenAI's Sora for video, Ameca and Miro Kai robots for presentations, and Hailu for content

creation. He introduced the "hamburger model," emphasizing human creativity as the key differentiator in AI usage. Davide Colla, in "You are useless: AI vs Creatives," shared his journey from banning AI to embracing it, particularly after an intern generated hundreds of perfume campaign proposals in a day using AI.

"The difference in the usage of AI is the human. All of you event managers out there in the world are now the difference in making AI truly impactful." — **Colja Dams, Redefining events: Shaping tomorrow's experiences**

Personalization at scale, driven by AI, was highlighted by Kris Justice in "Data-driven insights: Trends shaping venue sourcing in 2025," noting AI recommendations for session registrations and appointments. Henry Coutinho-Mason envisioned an "AI-powered meeting copilot" and tools like Bawdy for meaningful event introductions.

2.1.3 Data-Driven Decisions and Digital Transformation

The imperative to **"Modernize or Marginalize"** was starkly presented by Marco Otte-Witte, who warned that poor UI/UX directly impacts user engagement and conversions. He stressed that modern digital products require seamless experiences, delightful interfaces, and minimal friction. The "Unlock data-driven event success" session, moderated by Becca Hignett, showcased tools like Snapsight for AI-powered summarization and Crowd Connected for behavioral data tracking. Mark Maydon from Crowd Connected emphasized that dwell time is the physical event's equivalent of a page view.

The "Global Association Research Initiative" session, presented by Belinda Moore, revealed a critical gap: while 92% of associations believed AI would positively impact them, a mere 0.3% had meaningfully integrated it. This underscores the urgent need for the industry to embrace these transformative technologies beyond surface-level applications.

- **AI tools mentioned include:** ChatGPT, Google Notebook, Sora, Gamma AI, Microsoft Copilot, Make.com, Cvent AI, Ameca, Miro Kai, Hailu, Opus Clips, Descript, Suno, Aura app, Worly, Salesforce AI, Bawdy, Snapsight, Zenith AI, Crowd Connected, Expo FP.
- Reggie Aggarwal highlighted the importance of moving beyond generative AI (like ChatGPT) to Agentic AI, which can perform independent tasks.

2.1.4 Sentiment Analysis

The overall sentiment surrounding technology and AI was one of **cautious excitement and urgent optimism**. There was palpable enthusiasm for AI's potential to revolutionize efficiency, personalization, and creative output. However, this was consistently tempered by a strong emphasis on ethical considerations, data privacy (GDPR), the irreplaceable role of human

creativity, and the critical need for AI literacy and strategic implementation. The gap between recognizing AI's potential and its actual integration, particularly within associations, injected a note of urgency.

2.2 Sustainability, ESG, and Purpose-Driven Events

A profound commitment to sustainability, Environmental, Social, and Governance (ESG) principles, and purpose-driven event design emerged as a non-negotiable imperative for the future of the business events industry. Sessions explored moving beyond mere compliance to embedding these values into the core of event strategy and execution.

2.2.1 Integrating ESG Holistically

The "Elevating event sustainability with ESG-driven agency, brand and destination thinking" session, featuring panelists like Fiona Plumpton (London) and Moammar (Abu Dhabi), advocated for a holistic approach encompassing environmental, social, and economic impacts. **Sabine Burling**, in "Agile Sustainable Events," introduced the "magic pyramid," evolving traditional event planning (quality, cost, time) to include sustainability as a crucial fourth dimension. She **emphasized the SDGs' Five Ps (People, Planet, Prosperity, Peace, Partnership)**.

"Sustainability is not only about zero plastic or recycled programs. It's about aligning economic, social, and environmental goals. This triple impact that we need to achieve and making that alignment visible." — Angeles Moreno, Elevating event sustainability with ESG-driven agency, brand, and destination thinking

The "Transparenz als Chance – Nachhaltigkeit glaubwürdig kommunizieren" session, led by Annika Pfuderer, showcased Z Erlebniskommunikation GmbH's comprehensive approach, including materiality analyses and a commitment to climate neutrality.

2.2.2 Environmental Stewardship and Decarbonization

Numerous sessions detailed specific environmental actions. David Harrison, Natasha Richards, and Roger Lehner shared IMEX's own "Journey towards sustainability," highlighting initiatives like the Better Stands program, conscious menu choices, and the use of Ayala's TRACE tool for carbon measurement.

Sustainable catering was a significant focus. "Chicken or pasta? Ein ehrlicher Blick auf nachhaltiges Catering" (with panelists like Carolin Borchardt and Philip Glamin, and another session with Marion Pombach and Frederik Feil) discussed:

- Regional sourcing (ideally 30-50 km).
- The debate between reusable (Mehrweggeschirr) and disposable (Einweggeschirr) tableware, with innovations like Palmblattgeschirr and edible kohlrabi plates.
- Reducing meat content and offering plant-based options.
- Water consumption solutions like reusable branded cups.
- Partnerships with organizations like Tafel for food redistribution.

The "Driving impact through mindful, sustainable and inclusive eating at events" session, with Vanessa Sturman and Kim Arazi, noted that only 4% of mammals are wild, linking food choices to deforestation and advocating for plant-based eating.

2.2.3 Social Impact, Purpose, and Regenerative Models

The concept of events creating a positive societal impact was central. Alessandro Teichner's "How every event planner can do more good" showcased Colors for Good, a social enterprise employing in underserved villages by producing sustainable lanyards and RFID badges.

*"This lanyard you're wearing is not a lanyard. This is a story. A story of transformation. One knot at a time." — Alessandro Teichner, **How every event planner can do more good***

Guy Bigwood and Bella Shahsuvaryan, in "Exploring global trends and data insights in regenerative events and destinations," introduced **regenerative events** that aim for positive impacts beyond mere sustainability, citing Coldplay's tour as an example. They emphasized formalizing social impact strategies and addressing the behavior-attitude gap.

The "Destination social impact: Global case studies" session, with experts like Tuya Beyers and Dr. Edward Koh, distinguished between social impact (immediate well-being) and societal impact (long-term systemic change), highlighting **Singapore's FIRM approach (Frame, Ideate, Realize, Measure)**.

2.2.4 Communication, Transparency, and Avoiding Greenwashing

Authentic communication of sustainability efforts was repeatedly stressed. Tommie Eaton, in "Storytelling for Sustainability," criticized jargon like "carbon sequestration" and advocated for simplifying messaging, stating, "Jargon is the enemy of engagement." He proposed rebranding sustainability to be more accessible.

"Sustainability has created this echo chamber of people in the know of sustainability words who understand the terminologies instead of lowering the barriers and creating ripple effects of bringing more people into the industry." — **Tommie Eaton**, *Storytelling for sustainability: Turning ESG complexity into action*

The "Transparenz als Chance" session warned against greenwashing, referencing the cautionary tale of dm (German drugstore) and highlighting the upcoming Green Claims Directive. Bigwood and Shahsuvaryan also discussed the EU's research finding that 53% of sustainability claims are misleading and the prosecution of Air France-KLM for greenwashing, contrasting it with "greenhushing" (underreporting efforts).

- The need for robust measurement tools (e.g., TRACE, SHE platform, Climate Active certification) was a common thread.
- Destinations are increasingly embedding sustainability into subvention criteria, as highlighted in the "Subventions for good" session.

2.2.5 Sentiment Analysis

The sentiment surrounding sustainability and ESG was one of **urgency and evolving responsibility**. There was a strong consensus that sustainability is no longer optional but a core business driver. A sense of optimism was palpable regarding the industry's potential to lead change and embrace innovative, regenerative models. Overall, the tone was proactive and solutions-oriented, reflecting a maturing understanding of ESG's multifaceted nature. However, this was often coupled with a pragmatic acknowledgment of challenges, such as the cost of implementation, the complexity of measurement, and the critical need for communication to combat greenwashing. Frustration with jargon and the "sustainability echo chamber" was evident, alongside a strong call for simplification and broader engagement.

2.3 The Human Element in Experience Design, Engagement, and Connection

Amidst rapid technological advancements and pressing global concerns, IMEX Frankfurt 2025 underscored the enduring and arguably increasing importance of the human element in business events. Sessions consistently circled back to the core purpose of gatherings: fostering genuine connection, designing memorable experiences, and ensuring meaningful engagement.

2.3.1 Engineering Emotions and Designing for Impact

The "Art of Experience: Designing moments that move, inspire and transform" by Kim Arazi directly addressed the "epidemic of loneliness," particularly among Gen Z, and positioned

events as a powerful antidote. She explained how the limbic system processes emotions and forms memories, underpinning her multi-sensory approach exemplified by the "Root to Flower" dining experience and the "Wine Listening" event.

"Emotion is the heart of everything right now. From a scientific perspective, our brain and our heart are connected. The more we feel, the more we remember."

— **Kim Arazi, *The art of experience: Designing moments that move, inspire and transform***

Ferdinando Buscema's "Alchemy of Experience" introduced Magic Experience Design, defining magic as "epic, sex, Dionysian mist, and play" to create the "Wow Factor." He emphasized curating touchpoints, referencing his TNT (Tiny Noticeable Things) philosophy. Similarly, the "AMEX trends: Crafting unforgettable experiences" session, with Pia Leimke and Sofia Eriksson, advocated a neuroscience-based, 360-degree approach to event planning, including designing events in "theatrical acts" to craft an emotional journey.

2.3.2 Audience Acquisition Through Human-Centric Marketing and Storytelling

The "Audience acquisition: Event marketers unite!" panel championed a paradigm shift towards treating attendees as individuals. Nicole Osibodu's "Secret Family Reunion" exemplified creating FOMO through mystery. Daniel Hettwer introduced the "W curve" (anticipation-driven experience model) and used a Parmesan cheese analogy to illustrate how anticipation shapes perception.

"Anticipation drives experience. If you do have a poor anticipation of an experience, you already lower the experience."

— **Daniel Hettwer, *Audience acquisition: Event marketers unite!***

Roger Pride, in "How to create genuine difference and stand out," stressed brand personality and criticized generic marketing, advocating for the LOAF principle (Likeable, Ownable, Applicable, Farmable, Shareable). The "Putting meaning where our mouth is!" session reinforced this, with Roger emphasizing "moments of truth" and Pigalette presenting her "Emotion Change equation."

2.3.3 Fostering Connection and Combating Isolation

Enrico Gallorini's "The Secret Ingredients of In-Person Experiences" traced the evolution of human gatherings from prehistoric campfires, highlighting their role in belonging and countering modern isolation exacerbated by social networks. He quoted Wittgenstein, "The limit of my world is the limit of my words," underscoring the value of face-to-face interactions.

"This is the secret ingredient of the in-person experience: being here and now with our passion, our love, our body, our mind and our soul."

— Enrico Gallorini, *The secret ingredients of in-person experiences*

Shaena Harrison's "Wing people in action" session provided practical techniques for facilitating introductions and making networking more comfortable, emphasizing a "we" approach over "me."

2.3.4 The Power of Play and Creative Engagement

The transformative power of play in unlocking creativity was a notable sub-theme. Pigalle Tavakkoli's "Play to innovate" session highlighted the disparity in play habits between children and adults, referencing Dr. Stuart Brown's definition of play as "purposeless" and essential for an open, creative mindset (serotonin vs. cortisol). Matthias Renner's "LEGO® SERIOUS PLAY®" workshops demonstrated how hands-on, metaphorical model-building can break the 80/20 participation rule, tap into unconscious knowledge, and foster deeper conversations, particularly around complex topics like sustainability.

"When we use our hands to build, our brain starts working at the same time. And due to that, we have access to intrinsic or buried knowledge somewhere in our stomach." — Matthias Renner, *LEGO® SERIOUS PLAY® Using creativity for more sustainability*

Frances Vieras Blanc's "Daring to be seen: Half naked and fully immersed" drew lessons from burlesque to enhance event engagement, introducing concepts like the "shimmy of vulnerability" and "bump of engagement" to transform spectators into stakeholders.

- A recurring insight was that authentic human connection and emotionally resonant experiences are paramount, with technology and design serving as enablers rather than replacements for this core need.
- The challenge of diminishing attention spans (Stefan from Exclusive Collection noted human focus is now 8.5 seconds) necessitates more interactive, concise, and engaging event formats.

2.3.5 Sentiment Analysis

The sentiment around the human element in events was overwhelmingly **positive, enthusiastic, and deeply affirmative**. There was a strong sense of rediscovery and re-prioritization of genuine human connection as the irreplaceable core of successful events. Speakers passionately advocated for designing experiences that evoke emotion, foster belonging, and create lasting memories. The tone was often inspirational, urging event

professionals to embrace creativity, empathy, and innovative approaches to engagement (like play and storytelling). The call was to be more intentional, more human-centric, and more daring in experience design.

2.4 Leadership, Talent, and the Future of Work: Nurturing the Next Generation

The future-proofing of the business events industry is inextricably linked to its ability to attract, retain, and develop talent, alongside fostering effective leadership capable of navigating uncertainty. Sessions at IMEX Frankfurt 2025 delved into these critical areas, highlighting generational shifts, evolving skill requirements, and the transformative power of mentorship.

2.4.1 Attracting and Retaining Talent in a Changing Landscape

The "Future proofing business events by attracting and retaining talent" panel, convened by Destinations International, revealed significant challenges in industry awareness and unclear career pathways, particularly among graduates. David, a VisitScotland graduate, underscored this by sharing his initial unfamiliarity with business events. The panel advocated for:

- Earlier industry engagement in education and bringing industry mentors to universities.
- Diverse talent attraction beyond traditional event management degrees.
- Inclusive job descriptions focus on character and cultural fit.
- Flattening hierarchies and avoiding micromanagement. Ashley Ash emphasized, "I never call her my coordinator. I call her my colleague because she is equally as valuable."

Tracy Judge's "Rising Talent - Future-proofing your career" session highlighted that 62% of Gen Z would accept lower salaries for higher purpose, emphasizing the need for purpose alignment.

2.4.2 Evolving Skill Sets and the Rise of Micro-Roles

The skills required for the future event professional are evolving. The "Future proofing business events" panel identified adaptability, intercultural intelligence, crisis management, and proficiency in event technology (including AI) as crucial. Tracy Judge, referencing the IBM CHRO, introduced the concept of deconstructing traditional job descriptions into **micro-roles** to better align strengths with tasks and support skills-based hiring.

"When we work with our customers on what the need is, that's one of the things we're doing. We deconstruct the job descriptions and we create what I call micro

roles." — Tracy Judge, *Rising Talent: Future-proofing your career in business events*

The "Workplace Revolution: Bridging Generational Gaps" session discussed evolving team roles like "whisperers" for intuitive understanding and "futurists" for trend forecasting, alongside data analysts and inclusivity specialists.

2.4.3 Leadership in an Era of Uncertainty

Leadership development and effective management in uncertain times were key themes. Sarah Furness, in "Leading under fire," shared lessons from her RAF career, **emphasizing that modern leadership harnesses cognitive diversity, emotional intelligence, and psychological safety.**

"Today's leader is expected to harness the cognitive diversity in the room, to lead with emotional intelligence, to create psychological safety in a world where the only constant is uncertainty." — Sarah Furness, *Leading under fire*

Matt Garman's "The Unconventional Way to Better Leadership" highlighted that leadership wisdom often comes from unconventional experiences. The "Leading with empathy: Lessons from Atlantic crossings" session, featuring Josh Stinton, David Harrison, and Matt Garman, stressed vulnerability and recognizing potential beyond titles. The "Unveiling ELX: Leading global teams through uncertainty" panel, moderated by Chloe Richardson, explored the "leadership mirror" concept (introspection) and the importance of psychological safety based on Google's Aristotle project.

2.4.4 The Power of Mentorship and Networks

Mentorship emerged as a vital component of talent development. The "Rising Talent - The power of mentorship" session showcased initiatives like EKA Lift and LevelUp, and the value of both formal (City DNA, PCMA) and informal mentorship. Reverse mentoring was highlighted by Cat Kevern, where younger professionals offer insights on technology to senior leaders.

"As a mentor, I can tell you that the most value I've gotten is what I've learned from my mentees. They've got insights that can offer navigating the digital world, sustainability, and mental wellbeing." — Thomas Mauch, *Rising Talent - The power of mentorship*

The "Elevate your career with SITE Young Leaders" session, with Jeffrey Fehr, Jacob Smith, and Caoimhe Rice, underscored SITE's role in global networking, mentorship, and addressing the education gap in incentive travel. Cristina Hentschel's "LifeCareer: Redefining success in times of change" also emphasized building collaborative networks like Women in Events.

- The **"Swiss Army knife" analogy** (Tracy Judge) illustrated the ideal modern employee: **versatile and adaptable**.
- The **70-20-10 learning model (70% on-the-job)** was presented as a key framework for skill development.

2.4.5 Sentiment Analysis

The sentiment regarding leadership, talent, and the future of work was a blend of **acknowledged challenge and proactive optimism**. There was a clear recognition of the "war for talent," the urgent need for new skill sets (especially digital and strategic), and the imperative to adapt to the expectations of younger generations. However, this was counterbalanced by a strong belief in the power of mentorship, the value of unconventional leadership development, and the industry's capacity for fostering a more inclusive and purpose-driven work environment. Sessions on talent were generally empowering, offering concrete strategies for career growth and leadership. The focus on psychological safety, empathy, and vulnerability in leadership conveyed a human-centric and hopeful vision for the future workplace.

2.5 Diversity, Equity, Inclusion, and Belonging (DEIB): Moving from Awareness to Action

The Diversity, Equity, Inclusion, and Belonging (DEIB) sessions explored not only the moral imperative but also the business case for fostering inclusive environments, addressing systemic barriers, and ensuring that events are welcoming to all.

2.5.1 Gender Balance and Women in Leadership

The "DEI under pressure: Why gender balance is key" session, moderated by Sonja Thomas, revealed stark realities: women in the exhibition industry face career stagnation and biased succession planning. Panelists like Claire Semple (Informa) and Heiko Stutzinger (Hamburg Messe) shared their organizations' targets and challenges, with Informa aiming for 40% women in leadership and Hamburg Messe noting a lag despite signing the Carta of Diversity in 2008.

"I think the exhibition industry is lagging behind, and for me personally, I think there's some extra pressure for women."

— **Mieke Berkens, DEI under pressure: Why gender balance is key**

The "Defending women's rights: Female networks matter" panel, featuring Tanya Swam and Marion Schöne, addressed the predicted 300-year timeline for gender equality (Antonio Guterres) and emphasized the **Three C's for effective networks: Confidence, Capability, and**

Connection. The "Visibility leads to success: women show up" session underscored the need for women to be seen and heard to advance professionally.

2.5.2 LGBTQ+ and Non-Binary Inclusion

The "Approaching meetings from a non-binary perspective" session with LGBTMPA representatives Gary Murakami, Kyle Jordan, and Cameron Curtis provided a comprehensive guide to creating inclusive events. Key strategies included:

- Offering pronoun options on registration forms.
- Providing gender-neutral restrooms (and verifying implementation details like trash can placement).
- Ensuring diverse visual representation in marketing.
- Using Social Offset to support local LGBTQ+ organizations.

"Non-binary is really sort of an umbrella for anybody who doesn't necessarily feel that they fit in a strictly male or strictly female category."

— **Kyle Jordan, *Approaching meetings from a non-binary perspective***

The session on "Belonging for all: Perspectives towards empathy," featuring Sabrina Schoenmaker and Jack Ryan, criticized one-size-fits-all accessibility and highlighted the emotional impact of unconscious bias.

2.5.3 Accessibility, Neurodiversity, and Universal Design

David O'Coimin's "Using sensory design to improve event business outcomes" session was pivotal in discussing neurodiversity. He challenged the industry's "extrovert bias" and introduced universal design principles, arguing that designing for extreme needs (e.g., dyslexia, sound sensitivity) benefits all attendees.

"If you design for the extreme, you benefit the mean. It's a great tool to create better experiences for all." — **David O'Coimin, *Using sensory design to improve event business outcomes***

Practical tips included left-justified text for dyslexia-friendly signage and strategic use of colors and lighting zones. The "Belonging for all" session emphasized an adaptive mindset and the courage to ask individuals about their specific requirements, with Sabrina Westphälinger of Accor presenting initiatives like smart rooms with audio vision features. The European

Accessibility Act, coming into effect in June 2025, was noted by Kris Justice as a driver for increased focus on accessibility.

2.5.4 Caregiving as a Leadership Catalyst

The "From caregiver to changemaker: How care work fuels leadership potential" session, part of the She Means Business conference, reframed caregiving not as a career hindrance but as a source of valuable leadership skills like adaptability, emotional intelligence, and crisis management. Panelists like Stephanie Murray and Tobias Lovelace shared experiences and advocated for:

- A "blend perspective" over traditional work-life balance.
- Progressive parental leave policies (e.g., Fidelity International's 16-week paid leave).
- Workplace flexibility and authenticity in leadership.
- The importance of male allies in caregiving.
- A common thread across DEIB discussions was the move from mere awareness to concrete action, policy changes, and systemic integration of inclusive practices.
- The concept of "psychological safety" was frequently mentioned as foundational for DEIB.

2.5.5 Sentiment Analysis

The sentiment surrounding DEIB was one of **strong conviction and determined advocacy, tinged with a realistic acknowledgment of persistent challenges**. Sessions on gender balance highlighted both progress (setting targets) and frustration (industry lagging, systemic biases). Discussions on LGBTQ+ and non-binary inclusion were practical and empowering, offering concrete steps towards creating truly welcoming environments. The focus on neurodiversity and accessibility brought a fresh and vital perspective, with an optimistic view that designing for diverse needs ultimately benefits everyone. While the "300-year timeline for gender equality" (UN) cast a sobering shadow, the overall sentiment was one of proactive engagement and a commitment to change through education, policy, and intentional design.

2.6 Business Strategies, ROI, and Event Viability: Navigating a Complex Economic Landscape

The economic realities of the events industry, including rising costs, evolving client expectations, and the imperative to demonstrate tangible value, were central to many discussions at IMEX

Frankfurt 2025. Sessions focused on innovative strategies for budgeting, negotiation, measuring Return on Investment (ROI), and ensuring the overall viability of events in a challenging environment.

2.6.1 Mastering Event ROI and Demonstrating Value

The "Mastering event ROI: The good, better, best framework" panel, featuring Mathias Sondermann (SAP) and Felicia Asiedu (Cvent), emphasized aligning event objectives with measurement strategies. They discussed moving beyond attendance figures to metrics like Return on Objectives (ROO) and Return on Experience (ROE).

"The value of measurement of something digital and the value of measurement of your event and the value of measurement of something else that's in marketing, they should look similar because otherwise you are measuring your events against something that doesn't hold up against something else in marketing."

— Felicia Asiedu, **Mastering event ROI**

The "Unlock data-driven event success" session highlighted tools for sentiment analysis (Zenith AI) and behavioral tracking (Crowd Connected), stressing that "dwell time" is a key physical event metric. Combining qualitative and quantitative data to tell a compelling sponsor story was a key takeaway.

2.6.2 Budgeting, Negotiation, and Contract Management

"How to budget and negotiate contracts in today's challenging environment" brought together industry leaders like Catherine Chaulet and Brie Richards to tackle rising costs (e.g., Caribbean destinations seeing 65% price hikes since 2003). Key strategies included:

- **Creative contract negotiations:** addendums, attrition clauses, blended rates.
- **Managing F&B minimums:** exploring spa/golf minimums, concession valuation.
- **Innovative solutions:** Tier 2 cities, space optimization (Silent Disco), AI-powered experiences.
- **Financial considerations:** deposit schedules, funky payment terms, contingency fees, deflationary components.

Debbie Venn's session on "Contracting and managing legal risks" emphasized thorough supplier due diligence, robust liability clauses, force majeure provisions (lessons from COVID-19), and GDPR compliance.

"The supplier will normally not agree to unlimited liability. So it's how you then negotiate to meet in the middle as much as possible. A lot of the time you can tie it to, for example, the supplier's insurance levels."

— **Debbie Venn, Contracting and managing legal risks**

2.6.3 Venue Sourcing, Destination Trends, and Subventions

Kris Justice's "Data-driven insights: Trends shaping venue sourcing in 2025" revealed CSN data showing increased US planner interest in Europe, faster hotel RFP response times (65% of RFPs awarded to first three responders), and Wednesday as the preferred event start day. The rise of unique venues and the impact of the European Accessibility Act were also noted.

The "Subventions for good" session by Nienke van der Malen and Bregje Frens highlighted that while 77% of destinations offer subventions, only 6% have fully embedded sustainability criteria, though 40% plan to do so. Economic development remains the primary driver for subventions.

2.6.4 Agency-Planner Collaboration and Managing Expectations

"The events industry's Batman and Robin" session explored agency-planner collaboration, using frameworks like "good, fast, cheap: pick two" for budget challenges. Managing "execu-whims" (last-minute senior leadership requests) by involving stakeholders early and relying on production plans was discussed.

2.6.5 Event Viability and Risk Management

Ruud Janssen's "Why event designs fail" introduced the Event Canvas and outlined four pillars of event failure: lack of dialogue, vision, perspective, and empathy. He emphasized that events create value through behavior change.

"Events create value only through one mechanism, and that's behavior change."

— **Ruud Janssen, Why event designs fail and what to do about it**

Simon Garrett's "Risks in 2025: How should an event company prepare for a major event crisis?" focused on preparing for severe disruptions like power outages and cyber-attacks, introducing Gold (strategic) and Silver (operational) crisis management teams.

The SITE research presented by Padraic Gilligan in "How destinations can meet evolving incentive travel needs" revealed shifting preferences towards new locations and all-inclusive resorts, with safety, budget, and inclusivity becoming paramount in destination selection for the \$112 billion incentive travel industry.

- A common theme was the increasing complexity of the event ecosystem, requiring more strategic thinking, robust data analysis, and collaborative partnerships to ensure success and viability.
- The need for transparency in pricing and contracts was a recurring point.

2.6.6 Sentiment Analysis

The sentiment concerning business strategies, ROI, and event viability was predominantly **pragmatic and solutions-focused, underscored by a clear acknowledgment of economic pressures**. There was a strong sense of the industry grappling with rising costs and the imperative to innovate within tighter budgets. Discussions around ROI and measurement were earnest and strategic, reflecting a drive to demonstrate tangible value in a more demanding market. The focus on creative solutions, strategic partnerships, and sophisticated data use conveyed a proactive stance towards ensuring the continued viability and success of events. The call for transparency in contracts and pricing also suggested a move towards more equitable and sustainable business practices.

2.7 Destination Evolution and Collaboration

The role of destinations and convention bureaus is evolving significantly, moving beyond mere logistical support to becoming strategic partners in co-creating impactful events with lasting legacies.

2.7.1 Destinations as Drivers of Local and Global Impact

The "How convention centers are driving local change with global impact" session, featuring Gillian Officer (Te Pae Christchurch) and Said Al Shanfari (Oman Convention and Exhibition Center - OCEC), exemplified this evolution. OCEC's alignment with Oman Vision 2040 and Te Pae's role in Christchurch's post-earthquake renaissance demonstrated convention centers as catalysts for regional development.

*"We changed the whole philosophy. Then we went back and said, let's change our strategy and create a strategy based on experiences." — Said Al Shanfari, **How convention centers are driving local change with global impact***

The "Destination social impact: Global case studies" session, moderated by Vivian Xu, emphasized the distinction between social impact (immediate well-being) and societal impact (long-term systemic change). Case studies like the World Stroke Congress in Singapore

(illuminating 17 buildings) and the Rotary Convention 2024 (donating to a mangrove conservatory) showcased concrete impact initiatives.

2.7.2 Strategic Alignment and Co-Creation

"The big association rethink" panel, with Ciara Gallagher, Remi Deve, and Greg Carew, discussed Ireland's innovative approach of aligning events with government priorities. Gothenburg's legacy approach with an electric vehicle symposium tied to Volvo's sustainability goals was cited as a best practice.

"We looked at our program for government. We researched every single one of their strategies and policy documents to be very clear as to what their key objectives and goals were. And what we did then, we're now researching conferences based on achieving those objectives and goals we have within government." — **Ciara Gallagher, *The big association rethink***

The importance of co-creation between destinations, associations, and PCOs was a strong theme. Singapore's FIRM approach (Frame, Ideate, Realize, Measure) was presented as a structured method for achieving meaningful outcomes through proactive matchmaking by convention bureaus.

2.7.3 Innovative Destination Marketing and Branding

Roger Pride's "How to create genuine difference and stand out" session provided numerous examples of innovative destination marketing. He shared Wales Tourist Board's "Area of outstandingly bad mobile reception" ad and the "Feel the Hwyl" initiative, criticizing generic convention center marketing while praising distinctive approaches like the Harper Concert Hall in Reykjavik. The Faroe Islands' "Closed for Maintenance" and "Google Sheep View" campaigns, along with Vienna's "Unhashtag Vienna," were also lauded.

2.7.4 Collaboration and Knowledge Sharing Among Destinations

The concept of "coopetition" – destinations competing yet collaborating – was evident. The GDS (Global Destination Sustainability Index) movement's shared sustainability efforts were mentioned in "The big association rethink." The "Destination social impact" session highlighted the International Alliance on Impact as a platform for sharing best practices and advocating for impact-driven events. The "Design for vibrant places and sustainable transformation: Frankfurt RheinMain" session showcased the World Design Capital program, a collaborative effort involving 400 stakeholders to improve quality of life through design.

2.7.5 Leveraging Subventions for Impact

The "Subventions for good" session by Conferley revealed that while economic development is the primary driver for subventions, there's a growing trend towards embedding sustainability criteria. This research, surveying 115 destinations, indicated that 91% believe subventions can drive change, and 40% plan to embed formal sustainability criteria.

- Destinations are increasingly focusing on legacy and long-term impact rather than just immediate economic benefits.
- Collaboration with local communities, businesses, and academic institutions is seen as key to successful destination development through events.

2.7.6 Sentiment Analysis

The sentiment regarding destination evolution and collaboration was largely **optimistic and forward-looking, emphasizing strategic partnerships and shared purpose**. There was a clear sense that destinations are no longer passive backdrops but active agents in shaping impactful events and contributing to broader societal goals. The focus on legacy, strategic alignment with national agendas, and innovative co-creation models (like Singapore's FIRM approach) projected a dynamic and proactive future for DMOs and convention bureaus. The innovative marketing campaigns highlighted also added a layer of excitement and creativity to this evolving role.

2.8 The Evolving Role of the Event Professional: From Logistician to Strategist & Experience Architect

A significant thread woven through IMEX Frankfurt 2025 was the profound evolution of the event professional's role. The discussions painted a picture of a practitioner moving beyond mere logistics to become a strategic thinker, a data-savvy analyst, a creative experience architect, and an adaptable leader.

2.8.1 Skill Shifts: Beyond Operations to Strategic Acumen

The modern event professional needs a vastly expanded skillset. The "Top 10 tech skills defining the next era of meetings" session, led by Jeanne Sheehy and Sarah Timm, explicitly highlighted the need for AI literacy, prompt engineering, data interpretation, hybrid platform mastery, and cybersecurity awareness. Tracy Judge, in "Rising Talent - Future-proofing your career in business events," reinforced this by emphasizing that skills are the "currency of the future." She introduced the 70-20-10 learning model, noting that 70% of skill development

occurs through on-the-job experiences, underscoring the need for roles that offer experiential learning.

The "State of the industry" panel, featuring Carina Bauer, Kai Hattendorf, and Reggie Aggarwal, likened the complexity of event planning roles to CEO positions, suggesting traditional skills like Excel expertise are becoming obsolete in favor of more strategic thinking. This shift requires professionals to be adept at:

- **Critical Thinking & Creativity:** Carina Bauer noted these as key skills computers can't (yet) replicate.
- **Adaptability:** Identified by multiple speakers, including Rob Hosking ("Adaptable is the new sexy"), as a "superpower" in a constantly changing industry.
- **Communication and Storytelling:** Essential for conveying value, engaging audiences, and building relationships (Jose Ucar's "SIMPLER" approach, Tommie Eaton on sustainability narratives).

2.8.2 The "CEO of the Event" and Micro-Roles

The increasing strategic importance of events means planners are taking on more executive-level responsibilities. Tracy Judge's concept of deconstructing job descriptions into **micro-roles** addresses this complexity. This approach supports skills-based hiring and allows individuals to focus on their strengths, potentially reducing burnout. It also allows for more agile team structures, where individuals with specialized skills can be brought in as needed.

2.8.3 The Rise of Freelancing and the "Swiss Army Knife" Professional

The gig economy's influence is apparent, with freelancing presented as a strategic career move. The "Rising Talent - Freelance, fearless and global: Navigating solopreneurship in events" session explored the realities of this path. Matt Regnier used the "Swiss Army knife" analogy, sparking a debate on specialization versus generalization for freelancers. Stephanie Jayko emphasized that career stability for freelancers comes from continuous learning and adapting to market demands. Tracy Judge also used the Swiss Army knife analogy to describe the ideal modern employee – versatile, adaptable, and equipped with a diverse skill set, which freelancing can help cultivate.

2.8.4 Leadership in Complexity: Empathy, Adaptability, and Vision

The demands on leadership within the events industry are intensifying. Sessions like "Leading under fire" (Sarah Furness, Rob Hosking) and "The unconventional way to better leadership" (Matt Garman) highlighted:

- **Emotional Intelligence and Empathy:** Crucial for understanding team needs and navigating high-stress situations. Sarah Furness stated, "Today's leader is expected to harness the cognitive diversity in the room, to lead with emotional intelligence."
- **Adaptability and Resilience:** The ability to remain calm amidst chaos and make brave choices under pressure. Rob Hosking emphasized being a "palm tree" that bends with the wind.
- **Vulnerability:** Sharing mistakes and being authentic builds trust and psychological safety (Josh Stinton, Matt Garman).
- **Vision and Purpose:** Inspiring teams with a clear vision and connecting work to a larger purpose, as unconventional experiences often provide more profound leadership wisdom than formal training.

The "Unveiling ELX: Leading global teams through uncertainty" session further underscored the importance of introspection (the "leadership mirror") and creating psychologically safe environments, drawing on Google's Aristotle project findings. The need for leaders to model desired behaviors and support team members' growth was a consistent message.

- Continuous learning and upskilling are no longer optional but essential for career longevity.
- Soft skills, such as communication, collaboration, and emotional intelligence, are becoming increasingly valuable alongside technical competencies.

2.8.5 Sentiment Analysis

The discussions around the evolving role of the event professional carried a sentiment of **significant transformation and heightened responsibility, coupled with empowerment**. While the need for new skills (especially in tech and strategy) and the increasing complexity of the role were acknowledged as challenges, the overall tone was that these changes present opportunities for growth and greater influence. The emphasis on strategic thinking, creativity, and leadership skills (empathy, adaptability) suggested an elevation of the profession. There was a strong sense that event professionals are no longer just implementers but key architects of experience and impact. The rise of freelancing and micro-roles also pointed towards a more

flexible and potentially more fulfilling career landscape for those willing to adapt and embrace continuous learning.

2.9 The Future of Event Business Models: Value, Viability, and New Revenue Streams

IMEX Frankfurt 2025 dedicated significant attention to the evolving business models underpinning the events industry. Discussions revolved around the urgent need to redefine value, ensure financial viability in a cost-sensitive environment, and explore innovative revenue streams beyond traditional ticket sales and sponsorships. The overarching theme was a shift towards more strategic, data-driven, and impact-focused models.

2.9.1 Beyond Traditional ROI: Measuring Holistic Value

The definition of event success is expanding. The "Mastering event ROI: The good, better, best framework" panel stressed moving beyond simple attendance numbers to metrics that reflect broader business objectives. Felicia Asiedu (Cvent) highlighted the need for event metrics to align with other marketing KPIs. The introduction of concepts like **Return on Experience (ROE)** and **Return on Objectives (ROO)**, alongside the more traditional Return on Investment (ROI), signifies a more holistic approach to value assessment. **Mathias Sondermann (SAP)** even discussed the unique challenge of measuring ethics and compliance experiences.

"Events are not just a cause in itself. Events are very powerful marketing measure and they are part of a customer connection and customer journey. So they're not standalone." — Mathias Sondermann, Mastering event ROI

The "Unlock data-driven event success" session showcased how qualitative data, such as sentiment analysis (Zenith AI) and behavioral insights (Crowd Connected's "dwell time"), are being combined with quantitative data to paint a richer picture of event impact.

2.9.2 Rethinking Sponsorship: From Visibility to Engagement and Performance

Sponsorship models are undergoing a significant transformation. Richard Morris, in "Sponsor appeal: Making your audience a sponsorship magnet," argued that sponsors "don't buy the components, they buy the outcomes." He advocated for outcome-led sponsorship packages (e.g., "amplify your voice" instead of "satellite symposium") and understanding sponsors' internal KPIs, such as cost per lead and sales cycle length.

"Sponsors sponsor things because they have internal KPIs, they have what their company is trying to do to sell things or to market things."

— Richard Morris, *Sponsor appeal*

The "How to budget and negotiate contracts" session noted a shift from "paper presence" to "pay for engagement and performance," with sponsors seeking real-time data access and exclusive experiences like C-level roundtables or podcast series features. This demands a more sophisticated approach to demonstrating sponsor value.

2.9.3 Subvention Evolution: Funding for Impact

The traditional role of subventions is also evolving. The "Subventions for good" session, presenting research by Conferley, revealed that while economic development remains a primary driver, there's a growing impetus to link subventions to **sustainability and legacy impact**. Although only 6% of destinations have fully embedded sustainability criteria into their subvention schemes, a significant 40% plan to do so, and 91% believe subventions can be a powerful tool for driving change. This signals a move towards more strategic allocation of destination funding, rewarding events that contribute to broader societal and environmental goals.

2.9.4 Purpose Economy Influence: Balancing Profit with Societal Impact

The rise of the "purpose economy," as discussed by Gebert Janssen in "The rise of new economies: From experience to purpose," is influencing how event businesses define value. Companies like Patagonia and Tony's Chocolonely exemplify how profitability and social responsibility can coexist. This translates to events needing to demonstrate alignment with attendees' and stakeholders' values, potentially leading to new business models that prioritize positive societal contributions alongside financial returns. Degmo Daar, in "Redefining success, rebuilding systems and designing for impact," reinforced this by asking, "What if success isn't about how much is taken, but about how much is left behind?"

2.9.5 New Revenue Streams and Business Resilience

In the face of rising costs and uncertain sponsorship revenue (as noted in the "Global Association Research Initiative" and "What's the incentive travel pulse?" sessions), diversifying revenue streams is critical. The "Meeting the moment" session highlighted that associations are exploring new collaborations and revenue models to reduce dependence on single large events, a lesson learned from the pandemic. Kai Hattendorf ("State of the industry") introduced the concept of events as a "full-year subscription model," combining in-person meetings with ongoing content communities and digital dissemination, offering a pathway to sustained revenue and engagement.

- The ability to articulate and measure the multifaceted value of events—economic, social, emotional, and strategic—is becoming paramount.
- Flexibility in contract negotiations, exploring alternative financial models, and creatively packaging offerings are key to navigating the current economic climate.

2.9.6 Sentiment Analysis

The sentiment surrounding the future of event business models was one of **strategic adaptation and innovation driven by necessity**. There was a clear-eyed recognition of the pressures from rising costs, shifting sponsor expectations, and the need to prove multifaceted value. However, rather than a sense of crisis, the discussions leaned towards proactive problem-solving. The exploration of new ROI metrics (ROE, ROO), creative sponsorship packaging, evolving subvention criteria, and entirely new revenue models (like year-round subscription concepts) reflected an industry actively seeking sustainable and resilient business frameworks. The influence of the "purpose economy" also injected a note of optimism, suggesting that aligning business viability with societal impact could unlock new avenues for growth and relevance. The overall tone was one of dynamic evolution, with a focus on data-driven decision-making and a willingness to experiment with new approaches to ensure long-term viability.

3. Spotlight on Key Event Sectors & Dynamics

IMEX Frankfurt 2025 provided a valuable lens through which to examine the specific evolutions, pressures, and innovations shaping distinct segments of the global business events industry. From the strategic recalibrations within the association world and the fluctuating pulse of incentive travel, to the transformative power of mega-events and the pioneering efforts of individual destinations, this section delves into these key dynamics, revealing an industry actively adapting to new realities.

3.1 The Association Landscape: Navigating Purpose Under Pressure

Associations find themselves at a pivotal moment, compelled to redefine their value proposition and operational models. The "Purpose Under Pressure" report, presented by Belinda Moore, starkly illustrated this. While events remain the "heartbeat" of associations, **financial sustainability has become a paramount concern**. Rising costs and evolving sponsorship expectations are testing traditional revenue models reliant on membership, events, and sponsorships. A significant challenge highlighted was the **AI adoption gap**: despite 92% of associations recognizing AI's positive potential, a mere 0.3% have meaningfully integrated it, signaling an urgent need for digital upskilling.

This landscape is pushing associations towards a "Big Association Rethink," as discussed by Ciara Gallagher, Remi Deve, and Greg Carew. The industry is consciously moving beyond the traditional "heads and beds" metrics. Instead, the focus is shifting to **intentional impact across economic, social, and environmental pillars**. A prime example is Ireland's innovative strategy of aligning its event acquisition with overarching government priorities, thereby elevating the strategic importance of business events. This pursuit of deeper impact is supported by frameworks like the Copenhagen Legacy Lab and emerging AI tools such as Impact AIQ, designed to quantify event outcomes. Even subvention frameworks are being redesigned to support these broader impact goals, moving beyond simple delegate numbers.

Adding another layer of complexity, Amy Hissrich (ASAE) detailed how US-based associations are adapting to federal policy shifts. These changes have brought varied impacts across sectors, with professional, healthcare, and education associations often facing negative consequences like funding cuts, while finance and business sectors have sometimes seen benefits. A notable consequence has been a decline in international attendance at US events,

prompting associations to adapt through cost-cutting, exploring hybrid formats, and diversifying revenue streams, all while striving to remain vital resources for their members in uncertain times.

3.2 Incentive Travel in Flux: Optimism, Budgets, and Destination Shifts

The incentive travel sector, a significant \$112 billion industry according to SITE research presented by Padraic Gilligan, is navigating a period of considerable flux. The "Incentive Travel Pulse" survey, shared by Lisa Grimaldi and Shawn Sawyer, revealed a **dramatic dip in optimism among North American planners (46% pessimistic)**, a stark contrast to previous sentiment, partly attributed to geopolitical shifts.

Despite this cautious outlook, actual booking patterns have remained relatively stable, with an 18-month typical lead time. However, economic factors are now dominant concerns. **Rising costs and budget pressures are intense**, with 30% of planners anticipating cuts – the highest figure in four years. This is compounded by significant surges in AV and production expenses (20-22%). Geopolitical influences, including social policy changes and trade policies, are also heavily impacting destination choices, with safety, budget, and inclusivity becoming paramount. Some companies are even considering cash bonuses as alternatives to traditional travel incentives.

Destination preferences are evolving. While the US remains a leading destination, there's a strong trend towards **new, potentially second or third-tier locations, as well as resorts and all-inclusive properties** (favored for budget control). Padraic Gilligan highlighted that 67% of buyers are considering fresh destinations. Interestingly, while sustainability's importance varies regionally (higher in Europe and Asia), the critical role of local Destination Management Companies (DMCs) and face-to-face Familiarization (FAM) trips in securing business was unequivocally reaffirmed, outperforming traditional marketing collateral. Hotels continue to be the primary beneficiaries, capturing up to half of program expenses.

3.3 Mega-Events as Catalysts: Lessons from the Paris 2024 Olympics

The session on the Paris 2024 Olympics offered compelling insights into how mega-events can serve as powerful catalysts for urban, economic, and industry-wide transformation. Corinne Menegaux described the Games as an "accelerator of transformation" for Paris, fast-tracking

significant infrastructure projects like the Line 14 subway extension and fostering unprecedented collaboration among stakeholders.

Arnaud Chouraki noted the profound economic impact, with **98% of the Olympic Games produced by French event companies**, creating a legacy of expertise and opening doors for future international collaborations, such as with LA28. The Paris Paralympics also set new benchmarks, achieving record-breaking ticket sales (2 million) and full stadiums, significantly advancing the cause of inclusivity in major sporting events.

Sustainability was a visible thread, with initiatives like promoting reusable water bottle usage (80% of attendees) and a doubling of bicycle use during the Games. Bryan Churchill outlined LA28's ambitious plans for a "no-car Olympics" and a zero food waste initiative, demonstrating a continued commitment to these principles. A crucial, evolving legacy is the **robust knowledge transfer between host cities**, with Paris actively sharing insights with LA28 and Milan Cortina 2026. However, challenges inherent to mega-events, such as the substantial carbon footprint of international travel, intricate security logistics, and the demanding nature of long-term staffing, were also acknowledged as areas requiring ongoing innovation and management.

3.4 Destination Focus: Case Studies in Innovation and Impact

IMEX Frankfurt 2025 showcased several destinations that are pioneering innovative approaches to event hosting, branding, and maximizing their socio-economic impact, moving beyond traditional tourism-centric models.

- **Frankfurt RheinMain's "Design for Democracy"** initiative, as part of its World Design Capital 2026 program, exemplifies a commitment to using design as a tool for improving quality of life and fostering active citizenship. The Cultural Campus Frankfurt project, presented by Paola Alfaro d'Alencon, is a tangible example of transforming a long-vacant urban space into a vibrant, co-created community hub, applying Eleanor Ostrom's commons theory to urban revitalization.
- **Convention Centers as Engines of Community Development:**
 - Said Al Shanfari detailed how the **Oman Convention and Exhibition Center (OCEC)** is strategically aligned with Oman Vision 2040. Beyond its Elite Gold LEED certification and significant solar power generation, OCEC actively fosters authentic Omani cultural experiences and even played a critical role as a mass COVID-19 vaccination center, showcasing its deep community integration.
 - Gillian Officer shared how **Te Pae Christchurch** has been central to the city's post-earthquake regeneration. Its Carbon Net Zero certification and the seamless

integration of Māori heritage into its operations highlight a commitment to both environmental stewardship and cultural authenticity, bolstering local communities and attracting events like the Asia Pacific Seed Association congress, reflecting the region's agricultural strengths.

- **Distinctive Destination Branding:** Roger Pride's insights from the **Wales Tourist Board**, including campaigns like "Area of outstandingly bad mobile reception" and "Feel the Hwyl," illustrated how destinations can create genuine differentiation by embracing unique local characteristics and moving beyond generic marketing clichés. This was contrasted with innovative global examples like the **Faroe Islands' "Closed for Maintenance"** and **"Google Sheep View"** campaigns, and **Vienna's "Unhashtag Vienna"** initiative, all demonstrating creative and impactful approaches to destination management that resonate authentically with modern travelers and event organizers.

These case studies collectively underscored a trend where successful destinations are not just selling spaces, but are actively curating experiences, fostering local impact, and building a compelling, unique narrative on the global stage.

4. Opportunities and Challenges

IMEX Frankfurt 2025 illuminated a landscape ripe with opportunities for innovation and growth, yet simultaneously fraught with complex challenges.

4.1 Key Opportunities

The rapid evolution of technology, particularly **Artificial Intelligence**, presents unprecedented opportunities for:

- **Enhanced Efficiency and Productivity:** AI tools (e.g., Snapsight, Sora, Microsoft Copilot) can automate repetitive tasks and streamline workflows, freeing human capital for higher-value strategic and creative work critical for event success.
- **Deep Personalization:** Utilizing AI for tailored event experiences, from content recommendations to personalized networking (e.g., Bawdy), significantly boosts individual attendee engagement and overall satisfaction.
- **Novel Engagement Models:** AI opens avenues for entirely new forms of interaction and content delivery, such as AI-generated event soundtracks or AI meeting copilots, offering fresh, captivating ways to involve audiences.
- **Improved Data Insights:** Sophisticated AI-driven data analysis, including sentiment tracking (Zenith AI) and behavioral predictions, empowers organizers to optimize event design and more effectively prove ROI..

Sustainability and Purpose are emerging as powerful differentiators and drivers of engagement:

- **Brand Enhancement:** Authentic and transparent commitment to Environmental, Social, and Governance principles significantly builds brand reputation and attracts value-aligned attendees, sponsors, and talent.
- **Innovation in Offerings:** Designing events that create a net positive impact on communities and ecosystems (e.g., Coldplay's tour, Colors for Good model) positions the industry as a leader in responsible development.
- **Meaningful Impact:** Opportunities abound to utilize events as platforms for contributing to broader societal goals, driving policy change, and fostering tangible community development (e.g., World Stroke Congress legacy).

- **New Funding Models:** The shift towards subvention models rewarding sustainable and impactful event practices ("Subventions for good") creates new avenues for financing responsible initiatives.

The focus on the **Human Element** opens avenues for creating more profound and memorable experiences:

- **Deep Emotional Connection Through Design:** Intentionally designing events to evoke strong emotions and foster genuine human connection, as with Kim Arazi's multi-sensory dining, helps combat loneliness and creates highly memorable experiences.
- **Unlocking Creativity with Play & Interactivity:** Methodologies like LEGO® SERIOUS PLAY® and other interactive formats can unlock collective creativity, enhance learning, and make events more engaging, breaking traditional participation barriers.
- **Authentic Storytelling for Brand Differentiation:** Crafting compelling narratives that resonate deeply with audiences, such as employing Roger Pride's LOAF principle or Nicole Osibodu's "Secret Family Reunion" concept, builds strong brand personality.

Talent Development and Evolving Work Models present chances to build a more resilient and innovative workforce:

- **Skills-Based Advancement:** Focusing on developing versatile "Swiss Army knife" professionals through micro-roles and continuous, experience-based learning (70-20-10 model) creates a more adaptable workforce.
- **Intergenerational Collaboration:** Leveraging diverse perspectives across generations, including the insights gained from reverse mentorship, enriches solutions and bridges crucial experience gaps within the industry.
- **Purpose-Driven Careers:** Aligning organizational values with the growing desire among professionals, especially Gen Z, for meaningful work can significantly boost talent attraction, retention, and overall engagement.

Increased DEIB Focus creates opportunities for market reach and more equitable experiences:

- **Inclusive Design:** Designing events that cater to neurodiversity (David O'Coimin's sensory design), accessibility (Europe Accessibility Act), and diverse gender identities.
- **Empowering Underrepresented Groups:** Supporting women in leadership (Women in Exhibitions International, She Means Business) and recognizing caregiving as a source of leadership skills.

4.2 Persistent Challenges

Navigating Technological Disruption & Adoption Hurdles

- **Addressing AI Ethics, Privacy & Security Risks:** Ensuring responsible AI development, maintaining GDPR compliance, and robustly mitigating cybersecurity threats are critical as AI integration deepens and evolves.
- **Bridging the AI Adoption Gap:** Overcoming the significant lag in meaningful AI integration within many organizations, particularly associations, is crucial to avoid falling behind in efficiency and innovation.
- **Closing the Digital Divide:** Ensuring access to new technologies and providing comprehensive training to upskill the workforce in AI literacy is vital for broad adoption.
- **Managing Data Overload for Actionable Interpretation:** Moving from "drowning in data" to efficiently organizing, analyzing, and extracting truly actionable insights without succumbing to "analysis paralysis" remains a significant hurdle.
- **Simplifying Tech Platform Integration:** The difficulty of integrating the array of disparate event technology platforms (CRM, AI tools) continues to hinder data flow.

Realizing Sustainability Goals & Combating Greenwashing

- **Overcoming Cost Perceptions of Sustainability:** Addressing persistent client and organizational concerns about the perceived higher financial investment required for comprehensive and authentic sustainable event practices.
- **Measuring and Proving True Sustainability Impact:** Developing robust, credible, and standardized methods for measuring and reporting the long-term environmental and social impact of events beyond superficial metrics.
- **Ensuring Authenticity & Avoiding Greenwashing/Hushing:** Maintaining genuine transparency in sustainability communications amid increasing regulatory scrutiny (e.g., Green Claims Directive) and stakeholder skepticism.
- **Closing the Sustainability Behavior-Attitude Gap:** Encouraging both event attendees and organizing bodies to consistently translate their stated sustainable intentions into impactful actions and choices.

Preserving Human Connection in a Digitalized World

- **Combating Diminishing Attendee Attention Spans:** Designing compelling content and interactive experiences that effectively engage audiences with significantly shorter attention spans.
- **Authentically Addressing the "Loneliness Epidemic":** Creating genuine and deep opportunities for human interaction at events that go beyond superficial networking and truly foster a sense of belonging.
- **Balancing AI Efficiency with Authentic Human Moments:** Ensuring that the drive for AI-driven efficiency in event processes does not overshadow or diminish the irreplaceable value of spontaneous human engagement.
- **Moving Beyond Impersonal "Pitch Slaps" in Networking:** Shifting networking culture away from purely transactional and often impersonal approaches towards more genuine, value-driven, and relationship-focused interactions.

Addressing Talent, Leadership & Evolving Workforce Dynamics

- **Winning the "War for Talent" & Ensuring Retention:** Creating clear, appealing career pathways and supportive work environments is essential for attracting and retaining skilled professionals in a competitive market.
- **Managing Burnout & Prioritizing Workforce Well-being:** Addressing increased workloads and industry pressures by fostering supportive cultures and promoting mental and physical well-being for event professionals.
- **Bridging Diverse Generational Expectations in the Workplace:** Effectively catering to the varied needs, communication styles, and values of a multi-generational workforce, particularly the purpose-driven expectations of Gen Z.
- **Equipping Leaders for Volatility & Uncertainty:** Developing leadership skills focused on empathy, adaptability, resilience, and effective crisis management is essential for navigating a constantly changing global landscape.

Systemic Implementation of DEIB & Overcoming Barriers

- **Maintaining DEIB Momentum:** Proactively addressing and overcoming resistance to DEIB initiatives while ensuring sustained progress and commitment across the industry.
- **Addressing Unconscious Biases:** Identifying and mitigating ingrained biases in hiring, promotion, event design, and organizational culture to foster equity and inclusion.

- **Cultivating True Belonging Beyond Representation:** Moving beyond mere diversity metrics to create genuinely inclusive environments where all individuals feel valued, respected, and can authentically participate and contribute.
- **Standardizing Accessibility for Universal Benefit:** Working towards universal accessibility standards to eliminate inconsistencies and barriers, ensuring all events are truly welcoming and navigable for individuals with all types of disabilities.

Mitigating Economic Pressures & Ensuring Business Viability

- **Managing Escalating Costs & Strict Budget Constraints:** Navigating significant inflation in venue, F&B, AV, and labor costs with often static or shrinking event budgets requires innovative financial management.
- **Consistently Proving Comprehensive Event ROI:** Effectively demonstrating the multifaceted value of events, economic, strategic, and emotional, to diverse stakeholders in an increasingly data-scrutinized environment.
- **Adapting to a Complex & Evolving Legal Landscape:** Staying current with and ensuring compliance for evolving legislation related to data privacy (GDPR), AI ethics, sustainability reporting, and consumer protection.
- **Building Resilience Against Geopolitical Instability:** Developing agile event strategies and robust contingency plans to manage the impact of political shifts, visa complexities, and travel restrictions on international events.

5. Evolving Narratives

IMEX Frankfurt 2025 marked a noticeable evolution in the conversations shaping the business events industry. The dialogue moved beyond initial reactions to recent global disruptions towards more mature, strategic, and actionable approaches. Key shifts in narratives, audience insights, and emerging themes point towards a future demanding greater intentionality, integration, and impact.

5.1 Evolution of Key Topics and Strategic Imperatives

Several core topics demonstrated a significant maturation in their discussion:

- **From Sustainability Compliance to Regenerative Impact:** The conversation around sustainability has deepened considerably. While initial focuses might have been on basic eco-friendly practices or compliance with emerging regulations (ISO 20121, CSRD), the narrative now strongly emphasizes **ESG integration** as a fundamental business strategy ("Elevating event sustainability"). There's a clear move towards **regenerative events** – those that actively aim to leave a positive net impact on communities and ecosystems, as highlighted by Guy Bigwood and Bella Shahsuvaryan. The focus is shifting from simply "doing less harm" to proactively "doing more good," with concepts like the "magic pyramid" (Sabine Burling) adding sustainability as a core event planning dimension alongside quality, cost, and time. The dialogue also matured around **authentic communication**, with strong warnings against greenwashing and a push for transparent, data-backed storytelling (Tommie Eaton, Annika Pfuderer).
- **From Technology Adoption to Pervasive AI Integration:** If previous years focused on adopting digital tools, 2025 centered on the **pervasive and transformative impact of AI**. The discussion went beyond basic AI literacy to explore sophisticated applications like agentic AI (Reggie Aggarwal), AI for deep personalization (Kris Justice, Colja Dams), advanced data analytics (Unlock data-driven event success session), and even creative content generation (Davide Colla, Henry Coutinho-Mason). The "AI Hamburger" model (Colja Dams) and the emphasis on AI augmenting human creativity rather than replacing it indicate a more nuanced understanding of AI's role. Ethical considerations and the need for robust AI policies have also become central to this evolving narrative.
- **From Attendee Satisfaction to Deep Experience Design & Emotional ROI:** While attendee satisfaction remains important, the discourse has evolved to focus on **designing profound, emotionally resonant experiences**. Sessions like Kim Arazi's "The art of experience" and Ferdinando Buscema's "Alchemy of Experience" explored

the neuroscience of memory and emotion, advocating for multi-sensory engagement and creating "Wow Factors." The emphasis is on **Return on Experience (ROE)** and even **Emotional ROI** (AMEX trends session), recognizing that how an event makes attendees *feel* is a critical measure of success. This includes designing for human connection to combat loneliness and fostering environments where vulnerability and authenticity can thrive (Frances Vieras Blanc).

- **From Work-Life Balance to Purpose-Driven Careers and Holistic Well-being:** The talent and leadership narrative has shifted from a simple focus on work-life balance to a broader consideration of **purpose-driven careers, holistic well-being, and skills-based development**. Tracy Judge's session highlighted Gen Z's preference for purpose over pay and the concept of "micro-roles." The understanding of leadership itself is evolving, with an emphasis on empathy, adaptability, and drawing wisdom from unconventional experiences (Sarah Furness, Matt Garman, Josh Stinton). Discussions around caregiving (From Caregiver to Changemaker session) reframed it as a source of leadership skills, advocating for more blended and flexible work-life integration.
- **From Diversity Metrics to Systemic DEIB and Belonging:** The DEIB conversation has moved past basic diversity metrics towards a systemic understanding of **equity, inclusion, and true belonging**. Sessions addressed ingrained biases ("DEI under pressure"), the specific needs of non-binary individuals (LGBTMPA session), neurodiversity (David O'Coimin), and the importance of creating "safe spaces" where all attendees feel valued and can participate authentically. The emphasis is on proactive design and policy changes rather than reactive measures.
- **From Event Logistics to Strategic Impact and Legacy:** There's a clear shift from viewing events as standalone logistical exercises to recognizing them as **powerful strategic tools for achieving broader business and societal goals**. "The big association rethink" exemplified this by discussing how events are being aligned with government priorities and national agendas. The concept of **event legacy** – the long-term positive impact an event leaves on its host community and stakeholders – is now a central strategic consideration, supported by frameworks like the Copenhagen Legacy Lab.

5.2 Audience Insights and Sentiment Shifts

The sessions reflected and responded to palpable shifts in audience (attendee, sponsor, and stakeholder) sentiment and expectations:

- **Demand for Personalization and Purpose:** Attendees, particularly younger generations (Gen Z and Millennials), increasingly expect **hyper-personalized experiences** and demand that events align with their values and offer a sense of purpose. Hilton's "Meeting Maximizer Report" (Kelly Nolan) directly addressed this with trends like "extreme preparedness" and "pod squads."
- **Heightened Expectations for Authenticity and Transparency:** There's growing skepticism towards generic marketing and superficial sustainability claims. Audiences demand **authenticity and transparency**, whether in brand messaging (Roger Pride's "Somerset Test") or ESG reporting. The pushback against "evil tourism clichés" and greenwashing signifies a more discerning attendee base.
- **Craving for Genuine Connection and Interactive Experiences:** In an increasingly digital and sometimes isolating world, the desire for **genuine human connection** at events is stronger than ever (Enrico Gallorini, Kim Arazi). This translates into a preference for interactive formats, co-created experiences (LEGO® SERIOUS PLAY®), and opportunities for meaningful networking rather than passive content consumption. Shaena Harrison's "Wing people in action" directly tackled the "cringe effect" of traditional networking.
- **Increased Sensory and Cognitive Load Awareness:** Event planners are acknowledging the challenges of **information overload and sensory overwhelm**. Sessions on sensory design (David O'Coimin) and managing attention spans (Stefan from Exclusive Collection) reflect a growing awareness of the need to design events that are cognitively and sensorily accessible and considerate.
- **Value Beyond the Transaction:** Attendees and sponsors are looking for **value that extends beyond the immediate transaction** or information exchange. This includes demonstrable ROI for sponsors (Mastering Event ROI session), career development opportunities for professionals (Rising Talent sessions), and lasting positive impact for communities (Destination Social Impact session).

5.3 Key Inflection Points and Emerging Themes for 2025 and Beyond

Looking ahead, IMEX Frankfurt 2025 highlighted several key inflection points and emerging themes that will likely define the business events industry:

- **The "Intention to Action" Imperative:** Across all domains – sustainability, technology, DEIB, experience design – the call was to move beyond discussion and intention to tangible, measurable action and implementation.
- **AI as a Foundational Utility:** AI is rapidly transitioning from a novel technology to an expected utility. The focus is shifting from *whether* AI should be used to *how* it can be strategically and ethically integrated to enhance every facet of event planning and experience. The human role evolves to guiding AI and infusing creativity.
- **ESG and DEIB as Non-Negotiable Cornerstones:** These are no longer niche concerns or add-ons but are becoming fundamental to business strategy, brand reputation, and event viability. Regulatory pressures (CSRD, European Accessibility Act) will further accelerate this integration.
- **The Primacy of Human-Centricity:** Despite technological advancements, or perhaps because of them, the value of genuine human connection, empathy, events, and experiences designed with human needs at their core is being amplified.
- **Data as the New Currency of Value:** The ability to collect, interpret, and act upon data will be critical for optimizing events, proving ROI, personalizing experiences, and making strategic decisions.
- **Resilience and Adaptability in a Volatile World:** The industry continues to operate in an environment of geopolitical uncertainty, economic fluctuations, and rapid technological change. Agility, flexible planning, and robust crisis management strategies (Simon Garrett's session) are essential for survival and success.
- **Redefinition of "Value" and "Success":** Success is increasingly being defined not just by economic returns but by broader impact on individuals, communities, and the planet. This holistic view of value is reshaping event objectives, measurement, and design.
- **The Rise of Regenerative Thinking:** Moving beyond simply minimizing negative impacts, the concept of "regenerative events" that actively contribute to positive change is gaining traction, signaling a more ambitious and proactive approach to the industry's role in the world.

6. Strategic Recommendations

The insights gleaned from IMEX Frankfurt 2025 point towards a clear set of strategic imperatives for various stakeholders within the business events industry. To thrive in this evolving landscape, proactive adaptation, innovation, and a commitment to shared values are essential. The following recommendations are designed to guide different players in translating intention into impactful action.

6.1 For Event Planners and Agencies:

- **Embrace AI as a Strategic Co-Pilot:** Move beyond experimentation to strategically integrate AI tools for enhanced efficiency (e.g., content generation, task automation), deeper personalization (attendee journey mapping), and robust data analysis. Invest in AI literacy and prompt engineering skills for your teams.
- **Design for Deep Human Connection:** Prioritize creating experiences that foster genuine interaction, combat loneliness, and resonate emotionally. Incorporate multi-sensory design, storytelling, and interactive elements (like play) to craft memorable and transformative moments.
- **Champion Purpose-Driven & Regenerative Event Models:** Integrate ESG principles into the core of event design. Actively seek opportunities to create positive social and environmental legacies. Partner with social enterprises (e.g., Colors for Good) and advocate for sustainable practices throughout the supply chain.
- **Data-Driven Decision Making:** Implement comprehensive data collection strategies (qualitative and quantitative) to measure event impact (ROE, ROO) and demonstrate value to sponsors and clients. Use analytics to personalize experiences and design.
- **Cultivate Adaptability and Resilience:** Develop agile planning methodologies and robust contingency plans to navigate rising costs, budget uncertainties, and potential disruptions. Foster a mindset of continuous learning and flexibility within your teams.
- **Become Architects of Inclusivity:** Proactively design events that are accessible and welcoming to all, considering neurodiversity, physical accessibility (European Accessibility Act), diverse gender identities, and cultural sensitivities.
- **Strengthen Client Collaboration:** Work as strategic partners with clients, clearly defining objectives, managing expectations around budgets and "execu-whims," and fostering transparent communication regarding costs, value, and impact.

6.2 For Destination Marketing Organizations (DMOs) and Convention Bureaus:

- **Evolve from Service Provider to Strategic Partner:** Position your destination as a co-creator of impactful events. Proactively align with association missions and national/regional strategic priorities to foster events with lasting legacies.
- **Sustainable and Regenerative Tourism:** Develop and promote clear sustainability guidelines and resources for planners. Lead by example in destination-wide ESG initiatives (e.g., OCEC's solar power, Te Pae's Carbon Net Zero certification).
- **Leverage Subventions for Strategic Impact:** Redesign subvention programs to incentivize sustainability, social impact, and alignment with destination goals, moving beyond purely economic metrics.
- **Invest in Data and Impact Measurement:** Develop tools and methodologies (like Impact AIQ) to measure the holistic impact of events hosted in your destination, communicating this value effectively to government and community stakeholders.
- **Foster Local Ecosystem Collaboration:** Connect international event organizers with local businesses, academic institutions, cultural organizations, and social enterprises to enrich event experiences and maximize local benefits.
- **Innovate in Destination Marketing:** Move beyond generic selling points. Craft authentic, distinctive brand narratives (e.g., Wales' "Hwyl," Faroe Islands' creative campaigns) that highlight unique cultural assets and values.
- **Facilitate Knowledge Sharing and Global Collaboration:** Actively participate in networks like the Global Destination Sustainability Index and the International Alliance on Impact to share best practices and learn from global peers.

6.3 For Technology Providers and Innovators

- **Develop Human-Centric AI Solutions:** Focus on creating AI tools that augment human creativity and efficiency, rather than merely replacing tasks. Ensure ethical design, data privacy (GDPR compliance), and user-friendliness.
- **Prioritize Seamless Integration:** Address the challenge of disparate platforms by developing solutions with robust APIs and a focus on seamless integration with existing event tech stacks (AMS, CRM).

- **Innovate in Data Analytics & Visualization:** Create tools that help event professionals move from "drowning in data" to extracting clear, actionable insights. Develop intuitive dashboards and reporting features.
- **Advance Smart Event & Hybrid Technologies:** Continue to innovate in areas like smart venue technology, facial recognition (with ethical safeguards), hybrid event platforms, and immersive experiences (Metaverse, AR).
- **Support Sustainability & DEIB Goals:** Develop technological solutions that aid in carbon footprint measurement (like TRACE), promote accessibility (e.g., Navilens, AI captioning), and facilitate inclusive engagement.
- **Educate and Empower Users:** Provide comprehensive training and resources to help event professionals effectively leverage new technologies and understand their full capabilities and ethical implications.

6.4 For Venue Managers and Hospitality Leaders

- **Embed Sustainability into Operations:** Invest in energy efficiency, renewable energy sources (solar), waste reduction programs, sustainable sourcing (local, seasonal food), and water conservation. Aim for recognized certifications (LEED, ISO 20121).
- **Design for Inclusivity & Accessibility:** Ensure physical spaces meet and exceed accessibility standards (European Accessibility Act). Create sensory-friendly zones, quiet rooms, and consider diverse dietary and cultural needs in F&B offerings.
- **Become Community Hubs:** Position venues as active contributors to local community development, hosting events that benefit residents and partnering with local social enterprises and cultural groups.
- **Offer Flexible and Adaptable Spaces:** Design or reconfigure spaces to be multifunctional and easily adaptable to various event formats, technologies, and changing client needs. Avoid fixed furniture where possible.
- **Collaborate on Data & Impact Reporting:** Work with event organizers and DMOs to provide data that contributes to holistic event impact measurement and demonstrates the venue's value beyond just space rental.
- **Staff Training for Evolving Demands:** Equip staff to handle new technologies, understand sustainability practices, and provide exceptional service to diverse attendee populations with varying needs.

6.5 For Associations and Industry Bodies

- **Champion AI Literacy and Strategic Adoption:** Provide resources, training, and best practice guidelines to help members bridge the AI adoption gap and leverage technology effectively and ethically.
- **Lead on ESG Standards and Regenerative Practices:** Develop and promote industry-wide standards for sustainability and social impact. Encourage members to move beyond compliance to embrace regenerative principles.
- **Foster a Culture of Continuous Learning & Adaptability:** Offer professional development programs that focus on new skills (strategic thinking, data analysis, DEIB) and support members in navigating industry changes.
- **Strengthen Advocacy & Policy Influence:** Actively engage with governments and policymakers to advocate for the value of the business events industry and address challenges related to visas, funding, and regulation.
- **Facilitate Collaboration and Knowledge Sharing:** Create platforms and initiatives (like ELX or SITE Young Leaders) for members to share best practices, network, and collaborate on industry-wide challenges.
- **Evolve Membership Models and Value Propositions:** Move towards year-round engagement ecosystems, offering diverse value beyond annual conferences to meet the changing needs of a multi-generational membership base.
- **Support DEIB Initiatives Systemically:** Champion diversity, equity, inclusion, and belonging within the association itself and across the broader industry it represents, setting clear goals and measuring progress.

6.6 For Corporate Leaders and Event Sponsors

- **View Events as Strategic Investments, Not Just Costs:** Recognize the multifaceted ROI of events, including brand building, lead generation, employee engagement, and societal impact, beyond immediate sales figures.
- **Align Event Sponsorship with ESG & Purpose Goals:** Seek sponsorship opportunities that align with your company's values and ESG commitments, looking for events that demonstrate genuine social and environmental responsibility.

- **Demand Data-Driven Value & Meaningful Engagement:** Move beyond traditional visibility metrics. Expect clear data on attendee engagement, lead quality, and alignment with your specific KPIs. Prioritize opportunities for genuine interaction over passive branding.
- **Collaborate as Strategic Partners:** Engage with event organizers and agencies as strategic partners, clearly communicating objectives and being open to innovative, co-created solutions that deliver mutual value.
- **Support Workforce Well-being & Development through Events:** Utilize internal events to foster employee well-being, develop skills, and build a strong, inclusive company culture. Recognize caregiving as a valuable experience.
- **Champion Inclusivity in Event Participation:** Ensure that your sponsored events and company participation reflect a commitment to diversity and inclusion, considering the accessibility and welcome for all potential attendees.

7. Snapsight

7.1 About Snapsight

Snapsight is an AI-powered insights platform that transforms your organization's content into actionable insights. We analyze event sessions, surveys, industry reports, internal documents, and more, empowering your organization to make data-driven decisions that drive growth and innovation.

Insights-as-a-Service: Your Affordable Insights Solution Our team of experts partners with you to analyze your data and deliver customized reports that answer your most critical questions. We help you:

- **Identify Emerging Trends:** Uncover key themes, competitor strategies, and market shifts before your rivals.
- **Understand Stakeholder Sentiment:** Gauge member needs, public perception, or internal sentiment to inform your strategies.
- **Make Data-Driven Decisions:** Move beyond guesswork and base your choices on insights derived from your own data.
- **Save Time and Resources:** Let our AI and experienced analysts handle the heavy lifting, freeing your team to take action.

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